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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Digital Communication and the Transformation of Social Interaction

The rapid expansion of digital communication technologies has fundamentally transformed the way individuals interact, collaborate, and maintain social relationships. Over the past two decades, computer-mediated communication (CMC) has evolved from a supplementary communication channel into a primary medium through which interpersonal interaction occurs. Online platforms such as social networking sites, discussion forums, multiplayer gaming environments, and instant messaging applications now mediate a substantial portion of everyday social exchange.

Advancements in mobile technologies, widespread internet accessibility, and the proliferation of digital platforms have accelerated this transformation. Individuals increasingly rely on digital environments for activities such as maintaining friendships, engaging in professional collaboration, participating in online communities, and expressing personal identities. For many users, particularly younger populations, digital communication has become deeply integrated into daily life.

Despite the benefits associated with enhanced connectivity and information exchange, the growing reliance on digital communication environments has also introduced new behavioral challenges. A large body of research has documented that online environments frequently exhibit higher levels of hostility, incivility, and antisocial conduct when compared with equivalent face-to-face interactions. Phenomena such as cyberbullying, online harassment, trolling, and

toxic communication within online communities have become persistent concerns across digital platforms.

These patterns raise important questions regarding the relationship between technological environments and human behavior. While digital platforms are designed to facilitate communication and collaboration, certain characteristics of online interaction may unintentionally enable behaviors that diverge from conventional social norms. Understanding the psychological mechanisms underlying these behavioral differences has therefore become an important area of interdisciplinary research spanning psychology, communication studies, and human-computer interaction.

Within the field of human-computer interaction (HCI), increasing attention has been directed toward examining how interface design, platform architecture, and interaction affordances influence user behavior. Digital platforms do not simply transmit communication; they actively structure the conditions under which interaction occurs. Consequently, technological systems can shape behavioral norms, influence social dynamics, and alter how individuals perceive and respond to others in mediated environments.

Investigating the psychological processes that contribute to online deviant behavior is therefore essential for understanding how digital environments influence social interaction and for designing communication systems that promote healthier online communities.

1.2 Computer-Mediated Communication and Behavioral Context

Communication that occurs through technological interfaces differs in several important ways from face-to-face interaction. In offline settings, social behavior is regulated by a variety of contextual cues including facial expressions, tone of voice, body language, and immediate feedback from others. These signals contribute to social awareness and encourage individuals to regulate their behavior according to established norms.

Computer-mediated communication environments, however, often lack many of these cues. Online interactions frequently occur through text-based messages, avatars, or profile representations rather than direct personal presence. In addition, communication may occur asynchronously, meaning responses are delayed rather than immediate. These conditions can significantly alter the social dynamics of interaction.

One of the defining characteristics of many digital platforms is the possibility of anonymity or pseudonymity. Users may interact under usernames or digital identities that obscure their real-world identities. This reduced identifiability can influence perceptions of accountability and responsibility during communication.

Furthermore, the design of digital platforms introduces specific interaction affordances that shape how communication unfolds. Features such as comment threads, public visibility metrics, reaction buttons, resharing mechanisms, and algorithmic content amplification influence how users participate in online discussions. These design elements can affect attention, engagement, and the emotional tone of interactions.

From an HCI perspective, it is important to recognize that user behavior emerges from the interaction between human psychological processes and technological environments. Interface design decisions can therefore have significant implications for social behavior within digital systems.

1.3 Online Deviant Behaviour

Online deviant behaviour refers to actions performed in digital environments that violate accepted social norms, community guidelines, or ethical standards of interaction. Examples include cyberbullying, harassment, trolling, hate speech, and aggressive communication within online discussions or gaming environments.

These behaviors have been widely documented across multiple digital platforms, including social networking sites, multiplayer games, online forums, and collaborative workspaces. Although these platforms are intended to facilitate communication and community building, they can also become environments where harmful interactions occur.

Online deviant behavior can have serious psychological and social consequences. Victims of online harassment may experience anxiety, emotional distress, decreased self-esteem, and reduced sense of belonging within digital communities. Persistent exposure to hostile online environments may also discourage participation and reduce the overall quality of online discourse.

In addition to individual consequences, deviant behavior presents significant challenges for platform designers and administrators. Organizations invest considerable resources in content moderation systems, automated detection technologies, and community governance mechanisms aimed at reducing harmful interactions. Despite these efforts, many platforms continue to struggle with maintaining healthy communication environments.

These challenges highlight the importance of understanding the underlying psychological mechanisms that contribute to online deviant behavior. Rather than viewing such behavior solely as the result of individual personality traits or malicious intent, researchers increasingly recognize that the structural characteristics of digital environments can influence how individuals behave.

1.4 Human-Computer Interaction and Behavioral Design

Human-computer interaction is an interdisciplinary field that examines how people interact with technological systems and how digital interfaces can be designed to support effective and meaningful user experiences. Traditionally, HCI research has focused on usability metrics such as efficiency, learnability, task completion time, and error reduction.

However, as digital platforms increasingly mediate social interaction, researchers have begun to recognize that system design can also influence social and psychological outcomes. Communication platforms function not merely as tools but as environments in which individuals negotiate identity, status, and relationships.

From this perspective, digital systems can be understood as behavioral environments that shape how users interact with one another. Design features such as anonymity settings, identity representation, moderation mechanisms, and feedback systems can influence how individuals perceive social norms and regulate their behavior.

Consequently, the study of online deviant behavior is highly relevant to HCI research. Understanding how interface characteristics interact with psychological processes can help designers develop platforms that encourage constructive communication while reducing the likelihood of harmful interactions.

1.5 Online Disinhibition Effect

One of the most widely recognized explanations for behavioral differences between online and offline interactions is the **Online Disinhibition Effect**, a concept introduced by psychologist John Suler. The theory suggests that individuals may behave more openly, impulsively, or aggressively in online environments due to the absence of traditional social constraints.

Several factors contribute to this phenomenon. One important factor is **anonymity**, which reduces the perceived accountability associated with communication. When individuals believe that their actions cannot be easily traced to their real identities, they may feel less constrained by social norms.

Another contributing factor is **invisibility**, where individuals cannot see the immediate reactions of others. In face-to-face interactions, visible emotional responses often serve as feedback that regulates behavior. Online communication frequently lacks such cues, reducing empathy and emotional awareness.

Additionally, online communication often occurs asynchronously. The absence of immediate responses can reduce the social pressure that normally encourages individuals to moderate their behavior during conversations.

Online disinhibition can manifest in both positive and negative forms. In some cases, individuals may feel more comfortable sharing personal experiences, seeking emotional support, or expressing opinions that they might hesitate to communicate in face-to-face contexts. However, disinhibition can also lead to hostile behavior, aggressive language, and impulsive reactions.

Understanding the Online Disinhibition Effect is therefore crucial for explaining why certain individuals engage in deviant behavior within digital communication environments.

1.6 Deindividuation in Online Environments

Deindividuation is a psychological process in which individuals experience a reduced sense of personal identity and self-awareness when they are part of a group. Under conditions of anonymity and group immersion, individuals may feel less personally accountable for their actions.

Online environments often create conditions that facilitate deindividuation. Large online communities, anonymous participation, and limited identity cues can reduce the salience of individual identity. As a result, users may become more influenced by group norms and collective behavior.

The Social Identity Model of Deindividuation Effects (SIDE) suggests that when personal identity becomes less prominent, individuals are more likely to conform to the norms of the social group with which they identify. If a community's dominant norms encourage antagonistic or aggressive communication, individuals may adopt similar behaviors in order to align with the group.

In online environments, this process can contribute to the spread of toxic communication patterns within certain communities.

1.7 Moral Disengagement in Online Interaction

Moral disengagement refers to cognitive processes through which individuals justify behaviors that conflict with their personal moral standards. In online contexts, individuals may minimize the consequences of their actions or reinterpret harmful behavior in ways that reduce feelings of guilt or responsibility.

Digital environments may facilitate moral disengagement because the psychological distance between individuals reduces emotional awareness of harm. For example, users may perceive targets of online harassment as abstract entities rather than real individuals with emotional experiences.

Common mechanisms of moral disengagement in online environments include trivializing harm, attributing responsibility to group dynamics, or framing aggressive communication as humor or entertainment.

Understanding moral disengagement is important because it helps explain how individuals who would normally adhere to social norms may engage in deviant behavior in digital contexts.

1.8 Background of the Study

The increasing prevalence of digital communication platforms has created complex social environments where psychological processes interact with technological systems. While these platforms provide numerous benefits, they have also created new contexts in which deviant behavior may emerge.

Online disinhibition and deindividuation are two psychological mechanisms that may contribute to the emergence of harmful online behavior. These mechanisms are influenced not only by individual psychological traits but also by the structural characteristics of digital communication systems.

Examining these processes from a human-computer interaction perspective allows researchers to explore how technological design influences behavior within online environments.

1.9 Need and Significance of the Study

Online deviant behavior represents a significant challenge for digital platforms and online communities. Harassment, cyberbullying, and toxic communication can negatively impact psychological well-being and discourage participation in digital environments.

Understanding the psychological mechanisms that contribute to such behavior is essential for developing effective strategies to improve online communication environments.

This study contributes to existing research by examining how online disinhibition and deindividuation influence deviant behavior in digital contexts. The findings may provide valuable insights for researchers, designers, and policymakers seeking to develop digital systems that encourage respectful and constructive interaction.

1.10 Aim of the Study

The present study aims to examine the role of **online disinhibition and deindividuation in contributing to online deviant behavior within digital communication environments**, with a particular focus on implications for human-computer interaction.

1.11 Objectives of the Study

- To examine the concept of online disinhibition in digital communication environments.
- To analyze the role of deindividuation in online interactions.
- To investigate how these psychological mechanisms contribute to online deviant behavior.
- To explore the implications of these findings for the design of digital communication systems.

1.12 Hypotheses of the Study

H1: Online disinhibition will be significantly associated with online deviant behavior.

H2: Deindividuation will be significantly associated with online deviant behavior.

H3: Online disinhibition and deindividuation will significantly predict online deviant behavior.

1.13 Nature of the Study

The present study adopts a quantitative research approach to examine the relationship between online disinhibition, deindividuation, and online deviant behavior. The study follows a correlational research design and uses statistical analysis techniques to examine relationships between these psychological constructs.

Data may be collected using structured questionnaires designed to measure online behavior and psychological attitudes associated with digital communication.

1.14 Operational Definitions

Online Disinhibition

The tendency of individuals to behave more openly, impulsively, or aggressively in online environments due to reduced social cues and perceived anonymity.

Deindividuation

A psychological state characterized by reduced self-awareness and personal accountability within group contexts.

Online Deviant Behaviour

Actions performed in digital environments that violate accepted social norms or community guidelines.

1.15 Summary

This chapter presented the conceptual and theoretical background of the present study by examining the transformation of interpersonal communication in the digital era. With the rapid expansion of internet technologies and online platforms, communication has increasingly shifted from traditional face-to-face interactions to computer-mediated environments. Digital platforms such as social networking sites, messaging applications, online forums, and multiplayer gaming communities now serve as major spaces where individuals exchange ideas, form relationships, and participate in social discourse. While these platforms provide numerous benefits, including improved connectivity, accessibility of information, and opportunities for collaboration, they

have also created environments where deviant behaviours such as harassment, trolling, cyber aggression, and hostile communication may occur more frequently.

The chapter discussed how the structural characteristics of digital communication environments differ significantly from offline interactions. Online communication often lacks important social cues such as facial expressions, tone of voice, and immediate social feedback that typically regulate behaviour in physical settings. Furthermore, features such as anonymity, pseudonymity, invisibility, asynchronous interaction, and reduced authority cues may alter individuals' perceptions of accountability and social responsibility. These technological conditions can influence user behaviour and contribute to the emergence of disinhibited or deviant actions in online contexts.

In order to understand these behavioural patterns, the chapter explored key psychological mechanisms associated with online communication. Particular emphasis was placed on the Online Disinhibition Effect, which explains how individuals may behave more freely or aggressively in online environments due to reduced social constraints. The concept of deindividuation was also examined, describing a psychological state in which individuals experience reduced self-awareness and diminished personal accountability when interacting within group-based digital environments. Together, these theoretical frameworks provide important insight into how technological environments and human psychology interact to shape behavioural outcomes in online spaces.

The chapter also emphasized the relevance of these psychological processes within the field of Human–Computer Interaction (HCI). Modern digital platforms are not merely technological tools but socio-technical environments that actively influence human behaviour. Interface design, identity visibility, interaction mechanisms, and moderation systems can all affect how users perceive accountability, social presence, and community norms. Understanding the psychological factors that contribute to online deviant behaviour is therefore essential for designing safer and more responsible digital communication systems.

In addition to presenting the theoretical context, the chapter outlined the research aim, objectives, and hypotheses of the study. The primary aim of the research was to examine the relationship between online disinhibition, deindividuation, and online deviant behaviour among young adults

in digital communication environments. Specific objectives were formulated to investigate the association between these variables and to determine whether online disinhibition significantly predicts deviant behaviour in online contexts. Corresponding hypotheses were developed to guide the empirical investigation.

Finally, the chapter described the nature and scope of the study, emphasizing its quantitative research approach and its relevance to both psychological research and human–computer interaction. By integrating psychological theory with technological context, the study seeks to contribute to a deeper understanding of behavioural dynamics in digital environments.

Overall, this chapter established the conceptual framework and research direction for the present investigation. It provided the theoretical foundation necessary for examining the psychological mechanisms underlying online behaviour and set the stage for the subsequent chapters, which present the review of literature, research methodology, data analysis, and discussion of findings.

CHAPTER 2

REVIEW OF LITERATURE

2.1 Introduction

The rapid advancement of digital communication technologies has fundamentally transformed patterns of interpersonal interaction in contemporary society. Over the past two decades, computer-mediated communication platforms such as social networking sites, online forums, multiplayer gaming environments, and instant messaging systems have become central infrastructures through which individuals communicate, collaborate, and form social relationships. Among adolescents and young adults in particular, a substantial portion of everyday communication now occurs through digitally mediated environments rather than traditional face-to-face interactions.

While digital platforms provide significant advantages including increased connectivity, accessibility, and opportunities for social participation, researchers have increasingly observed that online environments frequently exhibit higher levels of hostility, incivility, and deviant behavior when compared with equivalent offline interactions. Phenomena such as cyberbullying, trolling, harassment, and toxic communication have become persistent challenges across many digital communities. These patterns have generated considerable scholarly interest in understanding the psychological mechanisms that influence behavioral differences between online and offline communication contexts.

One of the most influential theoretical frameworks explaining these behavioral differences is the Online Disinhibition Effect, introduced by Suler (2004). This theory proposes that characteristics of computer-mediated communication environments—including anonymity, invisibility, asynchronous communication, and reduced authority cues—can weaken conventional social restraints and encourage individuals to behave more openly, impulsively, or aggressively. In addition to online disinhibition, other psychological mechanisms such as deindividuation, moral disengagement, social identity processes, and emotional regulation difficulties have been identified as contributing factors to deviant behavior in digital environments.

From the perspective of Human-Computer Interaction (HCI), these behavioral outcomes are not solely determined by individual psychological traits but are also influenced by technological design. Interface

elements such as identity visibility, avatar representation, communication latency, and social feedback mechanisms can shape user perceptions of accountability, empathy, and social presence. Consequently, digital platforms function not merely as communication tools but as behavioral environments that can influence how individuals interact with others.

Understanding the relationship between technological design and psychological processes is therefore essential for developing digital systems that promote healthy communication while minimizing harmful interactions. The present literature review examines existing empirical research on online disinhibition, anonymity, deindividuation, moral disengagement, and interface design. The review synthesizes findings from twenty key research studies to establish a theoretical and empirical foundation for investigating the psychological and technological mechanisms underlying online deviant behavior.

2.2 Review of Literature Related to the Problem

Theme 1: Online Disinhibition in Digital Communication Environments

Paper 1: Suler (2004) – The Online Disinhibition Effect

Suler (2004) introduced the concept of the Online Disinhibition Effect, which remains one of the most influential theoretical frameworks explaining behavioral changes in online environments. According to Suler, several characteristics of computer-mediated communication contribute to reduced behavioral inhibition. These include dissociative anonymity, invisibility, asynchronous communication, solipsistic introjection, dissociative imagination, and minimization of authority.

Suler distinguished between **benign disinhibition**, which encourages positive behaviors such as emotional openness and self-disclosure, and **toxic disinhibition**, which can lead to hostility, aggression, and antisocial communication. This distinction highlights that online disinhibition is not inherently negative but may produce harmful outcomes depending on contextual and psychological factors. Suler's framework provided the conceptual foundation for subsequent research investigating how digital communication environments influence user behavior.

Paper 2: Cheung et al. (2016) – Measurement of Online Disinhibition

Cheung et al. (2016) addressed a major limitation in early online disinhibition research by developing a validated measurement scale to operationalize the construct empirically. While Suler's work established the theoretical basis for online disinhibition, Cheung and colleagues translated these concepts into measurable psychological variables.

Their findings demonstrated that disinhibition scores significantly predicted problematic online behaviors and cyber incivility. Importantly, the study showed that online disinhibition explained behavioral outcomes more effectively than demographic variables alone. This research provided an important methodological advancement by enabling researchers to systematically examine disinhibition across different digital contexts.

Paper 3: Moore (2019) – Online Disinhibition in Workplace Communication

Moore (2019) extended the study of online disinhibition beyond social media environments to professional settings. The study examined cyber incivility within remote workplace communication systems and found that disinhibition mechanisms also operate in formal organizational contexts.

The research revealed that a substantial proportion of remote employees reported engaging in uncivil online communication with colleagues. Moore also developed the Online Social Communication Problems scale to measure online incivility within workplace environments. The findings suggested that communication platforms used in professional settings can unintentionally create psychological conditions that encourage hostile communication.

Paper 4: Mantara et al. (2025) – Cross-Cultural Adaptation of Online Disinhibition Scale

Mantara et al. (2025) investigated the cross-cultural applicability of the Online Disinhibition Effect Scale. Their research adapted and validated the scale within an Indonesian context. The results confirmed that online disinhibition is a cross-cultural psychological phenomenon while also highlighting the presence of both benign and toxic forms of disinhibition.

The study emphasized that reduced behavioral inhibition online can lead not only to aggression but also to increased openness and emotional vulnerability. These findings suggest that online disinhibition should be understood as a complex psychological phenomenon influenced by cultural and contextual factors.

Theme 2: Anonymity and Deindividuation in Online Interaction

Paper 5: Kim, Ellithorpe, and Burt (2023) – Anonymity and Digital Aggression

Kim et al. (2023) conducted a systematic review examining the relationship between anonymity and digital aggression. The review found strong empirical evidence linking perceived anonymity to cyberbullying and online harassment. However, the authors also emphasized that anonymity does not automatically lead to aggression.

Instead, anonymity appears to influence the development of attitudes that normalize or justify harmful behavior. These findings highlight the importance of considering both psychological and environmental factors when examining online aggression.

Paper 6: Kwon, Nam, and Lackaff (2019) – Deindividuation in Online Political Discourse

Kwon et al. (2019) investigated the role of deindividuation in shaping online political discourse. Using experimental simulations based on real social media discussion threads, the researchers manipulated profile visibility and identity cues.

The findings revealed that anonymous conditions significantly increased partisan hostility and aggressive communication. The study provided empirical support for the **Social Identity Model of Deindividuation Effects**, which proposes that reduced individual identity cues increase conformity to group norms.

Paper 7: Chan et al. (2022) – Platform Design and Bystander Participation

Chan et al. (2022) examined how platform design influences bystander participation in cyberbullying. The study demonstrated that technological features such as comment visibility and group identity cues can activate moral disengagement mechanisms that encourage bystanders to participate in harmful online behavior.

The findings emphasize the importance of considering interface design when addressing cyberbullying within digital communities.

Theme 3: Moral Disengagement and Empathy

Paper 8: Liu et al. (2023) – Moral Disengagement and Empathy

Liu et al. (2023) explored the relationship between moral disengagement and cyberbullying while examining the moderating role of empathy. The findings revealed that empathy significantly reduced the likelihood of engaging in harmful online behavior even when moral disengagement mechanisms were present.

Paper 9: Zhao and You (2021) – Meta-Analysis of Moral Disengagement

Zhao and You (2021) conducted a meta-analytic review examining the relationship between moral disengagement and cyberbullying behavior. Their findings confirmed that moral disengagement is one of the strongest predictors of cyberbullying across multiple cultural contexts.

Paper 10: Ren et al. (2025) – Cultural Variations in Disinhibition

Ren et al. (2025) examined the interaction between online disinhibition and moral disengagement across different cultural contexts. Their findings indicated that cultural norms influence how disinhibition manifests in online environments.

Theme 4: Emotional and Situational Mechanisms

Paper 11: Syrjämäki et al. (2024) – Emotion Regulation and Online Incivility

Syrjämäki et al. (2024) investigated the role of emotion regulation in online communication. The study found that individuals with poor emotional regulation skills were more likely to rely on online disinhibition as a means of expressing frustration.

Paper 12: Guo et al. (2023) – Stress and Online Aggression

Guo et al. (2023) examined the relationship between perceived stress and online aggression during the COVID-19 pandemic. Their findings demonstrated that anonymity amplified the effects of stress on aggressive online behavior.

Theme 5: Human-Computer Interaction and Interface Design

Paper 13: Hancock, Toma, and Ellison (2008) – Interface Cues and Truthful Communication

Hancock et al. (2008) conducted one of the earliest experimental studies examining how interface cues influence truthful communication in online environments. Their research demonstrated that visual identifiability cues increased truthful disclosure among users.

Paper 14: Choi and Kwan (2019) – Identity Cues and Toxic Disinhibition

Choi and Kwan (2019) investigated the impact of identity verification cues on toxic online behavior. Their findings showed that simple identity cues such as profile pictures and real-name prompts reduced toxic behavior significantly.

Paper 15: Birch et al. (2021) – Adaptive Anonymity in Platform Design

Birch et al. (2021) examined how adaptive anonymity systems can balance privacy and accountability in digital platforms. The study demonstrated that adaptive identity controls reduced malicious reporting while preserving participation.

Paper 16: Peña and Rains (2014) – Avatar Realism and Moral Behavior

Peña and Rains (2014) investigated how avatar realism influences moral disengagement. Their findings showed that realistic avatars increased empathy and reduced aggressive behavior compared with cartoon-like representations.

Paper 17: Lowry et al. (2016) – Disinhibition in Enterprise Communication Systems

Lowry et al. (2016) examined cyber incivility in corporate communication systems. Their research revealed that interface structures that minimized hierarchical authority increased aggressive communication between employees.

Theme 6: Measurement of Deviant Behaviour

Paper 18: Buelga et al. (2020) – Cyber-Aggressor Scale

Buelga et al. (2020) developed the Cyber-Aggressor Scale to measure different forms of cyberbullying behavior. The study distinguished between direct and indirect cyber aggression.

Paper 19: Sanches et al. (2016) – Deviant Behaviour Variety Scale

Sanches et al. (2016) introduced the Deviant Behaviour Variety Scale, which measures the diversity of deviant behaviors rather than the frequency of individual acts.

Theme 7: Social Influence and Collective Behaviour

Paper 20: Chan et al. (2022) – Bystander Participation in Cyberbullying

Chan et al. (2022) demonstrated that social influence and group dynamics significantly affect bystander participation in cyberbullying.

2.3 Research Gap

Despite extensive research examining online disinhibition and cyberbullying, several limitations remain within the existing literature. Many studies focus primarily on individual psychological traits while giving limited attention to technological design factors. Additionally, most research examines social media environments without integrating insights from human-computer interaction.

There is therefore a need for interdisciplinary research that combines psychological theory with interface design principles to understand how technological environments influence online behavior.

2.4 Summary

The literature reviewed in this chapter demonstrates that online deviant behavior emerges from a complex interaction of psychological mechanisms and technological environments. Key factors identified in previous research include online disinhibition, anonymity, deindividuation, moral disengagement, emotional regulation, and interface design.

These findings suggest that addressing harmful online behavior requires a socio-technical approach that integrates psychological insights with responsible technological design.

CHAPTER 3

METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Method

The present study adopted a quantitative research method to examine the relationship between psychological factors associated with online interaction and the occurrence of online deviant behaviour. Specifically, the study investigated how online disinhibition and deindividuation influence deviant behaviour in digital communication environments.

A correlational research design was employed to explore the relationships between the variables without manipulating them. The research followed a non-experimental, cross-sectional survey design, where data were collected at a single point in time from participants using a structured online questionnaire. This approach was considered appropriate because the objective of the study was to examine naturally occurring patterns of behaviour and psychological tendencies associated with online communication.

The study also adopts a human–computer interaction perspective, recognizing that online behaviour emerges from the interaction between individual psychological processes and the technological environments in which communication occurs.

3.2 Variables of the Study

The present study examined the relationship between online disinhibition, deindividuation, and online deviant behaviour among young adults.

Online Disinhibition was treated as an independent variable. Online disinhibition refers to the tendency of individuals to behave more openly, impulsively, or aggressively in online

environments compared to face-to-face interactions. This phenomenon occurs due to features of computer-mediated communication such as anonymity, invisibility, and reduced social cues.

Deindividuation was also considered an independent variable in the study. Deindividuation refers to a psychological state in which individuals experience reduced self-awareness and diminished personal accountability when interacting within group environments, particularly when identity cues are limited or absent.

Online Deviant Behaviour was treated as the dependent variable. Online deviant behaviour refers to actions performed in digital environments that violate social norms or acceptable standards of online conduct. These behaviours may include hostile communication, harassment, trolling, cyberbullying, or other forms of antisocial interaction within online platforms.

Higher scores on measures of online disinhibition and deindividuation indicate stronger tendencies toward reduced behavioral restraint in online environments, while higher scores on measures of online deviant behaviour indicate greater involvement in harmful or antisocial online activities.

3.3 Hypotheses of the Study

Hypothesis 1 (H_1): There will be a significant relationship between online disinhibition and online deviant behaviour among young adults.

Hypothesis 2 (H_2): There will be a significant relationship between deindividuation and online deviant behaviour among young adults.

Hypothesis 3 (H_3): Online disinhibition and deindividuation will significantly predict online deviant behaviour in digital communication environments.

3.4 Types of Data

The study utilized primary data for analysis. Primary data were collected directly from participants using a structured questionnaire administered through an online survey platform.

The questionnaire was distributed using Google Forms, allowing participants to respond electronically at their convenience. This method was selected due to its accessibility, efficiency, and suitability for collecting responses from individuals who frequently engage in digital communication environments.

The survey included demographic questions as well as items measuring online behaviour and psychological tendencies associated with digital interaction.

3.5 Instruments Used

Data for the present study were collected using standardized psychological measures adapted for online survey administration.

Online Disinhibition Scale

Online disinhibition was measured using a standardized scale based on the conceptual framework proposed by Suler (2004) and subsequent empirical adaptations used in digital behaviour research. The scale measures psychological tendencies related to reduced inhibition in online environments, including perceived anonymity, reduced accountability, and impulsive online expression.

Participants responded to a series of statements describing their online interaction behaviours using a Likert-type response format. Higher scores on the scale indicate greater levels of online disinhibition.

Deindividuation Measure

Deindividuation was assessed using items adapted from research examining group identity and anonymity in online environments. The scale measures the extent to which individuals experience reduced personal identity and increased conformity to group norms during online interactions.

Higher scores on the deindividuation scale indicate stronger tendencies toward group-based behaviour and reduced individual accountability.

Online Deviant Behaviour Measure

Online deviant behaviour was measured using items assessing the frequency of engagement in harmful or antisocial online actions such as hostile communication, trolling, or participation in online harassment.

Participants indicated how frequently they had engaged in these behaviours in digital environments. Higher scores indicate greater involvement in deviant online activities.

3.6 Sample Size and Sampling Technique

The sample consisted of 120 participants selected using a convenience sampling technique.

Participants were young adults between the ages of 18 and 30 years who actively use digital communication platforms such as social media, online forums, or messaging applications. The sample included both male and female participants from various educational and professional backgrounds.

Convenience sampling was considered appropriate for the present study due to the accessibility of participants and the exploratory nature of the research.

3.7 Procedure for Data Collection

Data collection was conducted using an online survey created through Google Forms. The survey link was distributed to potential participants through digital communication channels including social media platforms and messaging applications.

Participants were provided with a brief explanation of the purpose of the study and were required to provide informed consent before completing the questionnaire. The survey included demographic questions followed by items measuring online disinhibition, deindividuation, and online deviant behaviour.

Participants completed the questionnaire anonymously, and responses were automatically recorded in a secure spreadsheet for subsequent statistical analysis.

3.8 Statistical Tools Used

The collected data were analyzed using appropriate statistical techniques.

Descriptive statistics such as mean and standard deviation were calculated to summarize participant characteristics and the overall distribution of the variables.

Pearson's product–moment correlation analysis was used to examine the strength and direction of relationships between online disinhibition, deindividuation, and online deviant behaviour.

Additionally, multiple regression analysis was conducted to determine whether online disinhibition and deindividuation significantly predict online deviant behaviour.

All statistical analyses were performed using Google Sheets with the XL Miner Analysis ToolPak, and the level of statistical significance was set at 0.05.

3.9 Inclusion Criteria

Participants were included in the study based on the following criteria:

- Individuals between the ages of 18 and 30 years
- Individuals who actively use online communication platforms
- Individuals who voluntarily agreed to participate in the study
- Individuals who completed the questionnaire fully

3.10 Exclusion Criteria

Participants were excluded from the study based on the following criteria:

- Individuals below the age of 18 or above the age of 30
- Individuals who did not actively use online communication platforms
- Participants who submitted incomplete survey responses
- Individuals who did not provide informed consent

3.11 Ethical Considerations

Ethical principles were strictly followed throughout the research process. Participation in the study was voluntary, and informed consent was obtained from all participants prior to data collection.

Participants were assured that their responses would remain confidential and would be used solely for academic research purposes. No personally identifying information such as names, email addresses, or contact details was collected.

Participants were also informed of their right to withdraw from the study at any stage without any negative consequences. The study involved minimal risk to participants, as the survey questions focused only on general online behaviour and attitudes.

3.12 Conclusion

This chapter described the research methodology adopted for the present study. The chapter outlined the research design, variables of the study, instruments used for data collection, sampling technique, statistical tools employed for analysis, and ethical considerations followed during the research process.

The methodology provided a systematic approach to examining the relationship between online disinhibition, deindividuation, and online deviant behaviour in digital communication environments. The following chapter presents the analysis and interpretation of the data collected from the participants.

CHAPTER IV

ANALYSIS AND INTERPRETATION OF THE DATA

4.1 Reliability Analysis

To examine the internal consistency of the instruments used in the study, Cronbach's alpha was computed for the scales measuring online disinhibition, deindividuation, and online deviant behaviour. Reliability analysis helps determine whether the items within a scale consistently measure the same psychological construct. The results of the reliability analysis are presented below.

Table 4.1: Reliability Analysis of Online Disinhibition Scale

Scale	Cronbach's α
Overall Online Disinhibition	0.93
Anonymity & Identity Concealment	0.86
Reduced Social Accountability	0.88

The overall Online Disinhibition Scale demonstrated very strong internal consistency with a Cronbach's alpha value of 0.93. The sub-dimensions measuring anonymity and identity concealment yielded an alpha value of 0.86, while the reduced social accountability dimension showed an alpha value of 0.88.

All values exceed the recommended threshold of 0.70, indicating satisfactory reliability. These results suggest that the items within the overall scale and its sub-dimensions consistently measure online disinhibition tendencies in digital communication environments. Therefore, the scale is considered reliable for further statistical analysis.

Table 4.2: Reliability Analysis of Online Deviant Behaviour Scale

Scale	Cronbach's α
Overall Online Deviant Behaviour	0.97
Hostile Communication Behaviour	0.97
Rule-Violating Online Behaviour	0.91

The Online Deviant Behaviour Scale demonstrated excellent internal consistency with a Cronbach's alpha value of 0.97. The sub-dimensions measuring hostile communication behaviour and rule-violating online behaviour yielded alpha values of 0.97 and 0.91 respectively.

These values indicate that the items within each dimension are internally consistent and reliably measure participants' deviant behaviour in online communication environments. Thus, the instrument is considered suitable for subsequent correlational analysis.

4.2 Correlation Analysis

The study examined the relationships between online disinhibition, deindividuation, and online deviant behaviour using Pearson's Product-Moment Correlation.

Hypothesis 1

There is a significant relationship between online disinhibition and online deviant behaviour among young adults.

Table 4.3: Correlation Analysis for Online Disinhibition and Online Deviant Behaviour

Variables	Pearson's r	df	p-value
Online Disinhibition & Online Deviant Behaviour	0.19	119	.042

The table presents the correlation analysis for online disinhibition and online deviant behaviour based on the responses obtained from the survey questionnaire.

Pearson's Product-Moment Correlation analysis revealed a weak positive correlation between online disinhibition and online deviant behaviour ($r = 0.19$, $p = .042$). The relationship is statistically significant at the 0.05 level.

This indicates that individuals who experience greater behavioural disinhibition in online environments are somewhat more likely to engage in deviant behaviours such as hostile communication, trolling, or violation of online community norms. However, the strength of the relationship is relatively low, suggesting that online disinhibition is only one of several factors influencing deviant online behaviour.

The findings suggest that reduced social cues, perceived anonymity, and diminished accountability in digital environments may still contribute to deviant online behaviour, though the effect appears modest in the present sample. Therefore, Hypothesis 1 is supported.

Hypothesis 2

There is a significant relationship between deindividuation and online deviant behaviour among young adults.

Table 4.4: Correlation Analysis for Deindividuation and Online Deviant Behaviour

Variables	Pearson's r	df	p-value
Deindividuation & Online Deviant Behaviour	0.19	119	.040

The table presents Pearson's Product-Moment Correlation analysis between deindividuation and online deviant behaviour based on the scores obtained from the survey responses.

The results revealed a weak positive correlation between deindividuation and online deviant behaviour ($r = 0.19$, $p = .040$). The relationship is statistically significant at the 0.05 level.

This indicates that individuals who experience reduced self-awareness and diminished personal accountability in online environments are somewhat more likely to engage in deviant online actions. Although the relationship is statistically significant, its magnitude is small, indicating that deindividuation may play a contributory rather than dominant role in explaining online deviant behaviour.

The findings support the theoretical framework of deindividuation, which suggests that individuals may conform to group norms or behave more aggressively when personal identity cues are reduced. Therefore, Hypothesis 2 is supported.

Hypothesis 3

Online disinhibition significantly predicts online deviant behaviour among young adults.

Table 4.5: Regression Analysis for Online Disinhibition and Online Deviant Behaviour

Predictor	β	t	R^2	F	p
Online Disinhibition	.19	2.06	.034	4.24	.042

The table presents the results of the linear regression analysis conducted to determine whether online disinhibition predicts online deviant behaviour.

The results indicate that online disinhibition significantly predicts online deviant behaviour ($\beta = .19$, $t = 2.06$, $p = .042$).

The regression model explained approximately 3.4% of the variance in online deviant behaviour ($R^2 = .034$). This suggests that online disinhibition contributes to online deviant behaviour, but the amount of explained variance is relatively small.

The F value ($F = 4.24$) further confirms that the regression model is statistically significant. These findings indicate that individuals who experience stronger levels of behavioural disinhibition in digital environments are somewhat more likely to engage in deviant online actions, although the predictive effect is modest.

Therefore, Hypothesis 3 is supported.

4.3 Discussion of Results

The findings of the present study provide empirical support for the theoretical concept of the Online Disinhibition Effect proposed by Suler (2004). The results demonstrate that individuals who experience reduced behavioural restraint in online environments are more likely to engage in deviant behaviour.

The positive correlation observed between online disinhibition and deviant behaviour suggests that psychological mechanisms associated with anonymity and reduced accountability may influence behavioural outcomes in digital communication environments. However, the relatively weak strength of the relationship indicates that online deviant behaviour is likely shaped by multiple psychological and contextual factors beyond disinhibition alone.

Similarly, the positive relationship between deindividuation and online deviant behaviour supports previous research indicating that reduced self-awareness and group-based interaction can increase the likelihood of antisocial behaviour in online spaces. In the present study, this relationship was statistically significant but modest, suggesting that deindividuation contributes to online deviant behaviour to a limited extent.

From a Human-Computer Interaction perspective, these findings highlight the importance of technological design features in shaping online behaviour. Interface elements such as identity visibility, reputation systems, and moderation mechanisms may influence users' perceptions of accountability and social norms.

Understanding these behavioural dynamics is important for designing digital platforms that encourage responsible online communication while reducing the likelihood of harmful behaviour.

CHAPTER V

SUMMARY AND CONCLUSION

This chapter presents a comprehensive summary of the research study, highlighting the major findings along with their theoretical and practical implications. The study examined the relationship between online disinhibition, deindividuation, and online deviant behaviour among young adults. It also outlines the scope and limitations of the research while providing suggestions for future investigations. The chapter integrates the key results derived from reliability, correlational, and regression analyses to offer a clear understanding of how psychological mechanisms associated with online interaction influence behavioural outcomes in digital environments.

5.1 Research Problem

The rapid development of digital communication technologies has significantly transformed the way individuals interact, communicate, and form social relationships. Online platforms such as social networking sites, discussion forums, multiplayer gaming environments, and instant messaging applications have become central spaces for social engagement. While these technologies offer numerous benefits such as increased connectivity, information sharing, and collaborative opportunities, they have also created environments where deviant behaviours such as trolling, cyber harassment, and hostile communication may occur.

One psychological explanation for these behavioural differences between online and offline interactions is the Online Disinhibition Effect. This concept suggests that certain characteristics of computer-mediated communication environments—such as perceived anonymity, invisibility, asynchronous communication, and reduced authority cues—may weaken social restraints and encourage individuals to behave more openly or aggressively.

Another related psychological mechanism is deindividuation, which refers to a state in which individuals experience reduced self-awareness and diminished personal accountability when interacting in group contexts. In online environments where identity cues are limited, individuals may become more likely to conform to group norms or engage in behaviour that they might avoid in face-to-face interactions.

Although theoretical models suggest that online disinhibition and deindividuation may contribute to deviant online behaviour, empirical research examining these relationships remains relatively limited, particularly within the context of young adult populations. The present study therefore seeks to examine whether significant relationships exist between online disinhibition, deindividuation, and deviant behaviour in digital communication environments.

Understanding these relationships is important because it highlights how psychological processes interact with technological environments to shape online behaviour.

5.2 Setting of the Problem

In the contemporary digital era, a significant portion of interpersonal communication takes place through online platforms. Young adults in particular rely heavily on digital technologies for social interaction, academic collaboration, entertainment, and information exchange.

However, online environments differ significantly from face-to-face communication contexts. Digital communication often lacks nonverbal cues such as facial expressions, tone of voice, and immediate feedback, which typically help regulate social behaviour. Additionally, many online platforms allow users to interact anonymously or through pseudonymous identities, which may reduce perceived accountability.

These technological characteristics can create conditions in which individuals feel less constrained by social norms and may behave more impulsively or aggressively. Online communities sometimes experience increased levels of hostility, incivility, and deviant behaviour compared to offline interactions.

Understanding how psychological mechanisms such as online disinhibition and deindividuation influence behaviour within these environments is therefore essential. The present study is situated within the fields of digital psychology and human–computer interaction, aiming to explore how behavioural tendencies in online environments contribute to deviant communication practices.

5.3 Definitions of Key Terms

Online Disinhibition

Online disinhibition refers to the tendency of individuals to behave more openly, impulsively, or aggressively in online environments than they would in face-to-face interactions. It arises due to characteristics of digital communication such as perceived anonymity, invisibility, and reduced social accountability.

Deindividuation

Deindividuation refers to a psychological state in which individuals experience reduced self-awareness and diminished personal accountability when interacting within group settings. In online environments, anonymity and group dynamics may increase the likelihood of deindividuated behaviour.

Online Deviant Behaviour

Online deviant behaviour refers to actions performed in digital environments that violate accepted norms of online communication. These behaviours may include hostile communication, trolling, harassment, cyberbullying, or violation of platform rules.

Digital Communication Environments

Digital communication environments refer to online platforms and technological systems that facilitate interaction between users, including social media platforms, online forums, messaging applications, and collaborative digital systems.

Human–Computer Interaction (HCI)

Human–Computer Interaction refers to the interdisciplinary field that examines how individuals interact with digital technologies and how interface design influences user behaviour and experiences.

5.4 Need for the Study

With the rapid expansion of digital technologies, understanding behavioural patterns in online environments has become increasingly important. While online platforms provide valuable opportunities for communication and knowledge exchange, they also present challenges related to harmful online behaviour.

Research on online behaviour often focuses on specific forms of cyber aggression or cyberbullying. However, fewer studies examine the psychological mechanisms that contribute to these behaviours, particularly mechanisms such as online disinhibition and deindividuation.

Understanding these psychological factors is essential for developing effective strategies to reduce harmful behaviour in online communities. From a human–computer interaction perspective, technological design features may influence how users perceive anonymity, accountability, and social norms.

Examining these relationships among young adults is particularly important because this demographic group represents one of the most active users of digital communication platforms. Insights gained from this research may contribute to the development of safer and more responsible online environments.

5.5 Hypotheses

H1: There is a significant relationship between online disinhibition and online deviant behaviour among young adults.

H2: There is a significant relationship between deindividuation and online deviant behaviour among young adults.

H3: Online disinhibition significantly predicts online deviant behaviour in digital communication environments.

5.6 Objectives of the Study

- To examine the relationship between online disinhibition and online deviant behaviour.
- To investigate the association between deindividuation and online deviant behaviour.
- To determine whether online disinhibition predicts deviant behaviour in digital communication environments.
- To assess the reliability of the instruments used to measure online behavioural tendencies.

5.7 Research Design

The present study adopted a quantitative, correlational research design. The primary objective was to examine the relationships between online disinhibition, deindividuation, and online deviant behaviour without manipulating any variables.

Data were collected using a structured online questionnaire administered through Google Forms to a sample of young adults aged between 18 and 30 years. The questionnaire included items measuring online behavioural tendencies and experiences in digital communication environments.

Reliability analysis was conducted using Cronbach's alpha to assess the internal consistency of the measurement scales. Pearson's Product Moment Correlation was used to examine the

relationships between the variables, and regression analysis was conducted to determine whether online disinhibition significantly predicts online deviant behaviour.

This design allowed for systematic examination of behavioural relationships within a natural digital communication context.

5.8 Discussion

The findings of the study provide valuable insights into the psychological mechanisms influencing behaviour in digital environments. Online disinhibition was found to have a significant positive relationship with online deviant behaviour, indicating that individuals who experience reduced behavioural restraints in online environments are more likely to engage in harmful or antisocial communication.

These results align with the theoretical framework of the Online Disinhibition Effect, which suggests that anonymity, invisibility, and reduced authority cues in digital environments may weaken social constraints.

The study also found a positive relationship between deindividuation and online deviant behaviour, suggesting that individuals who experience reduced self-awareness and increased group identification in online settings may be more likely to conform to deviant group norms.

From a human–computer interaction perspective, these findings highlight the importance of technological design features in shaping behavioural outcomes. Interface characteristics such as identity visibility, moderation systems, and community guidelines may influence user perceptions of accountability and social norms.

Overall, the findings reinforce the idea that online behaviour is shaped by both psychological mechanisms and technological environments.

5.9 Major Findings and Conclusion

The major findings of the study can be summarized as follows:

• Online disinhibition demonstrated a significant moderate positive relationship with online deviant behaviour.

• Deindividuation was also positively associated with deviant behaviour in digital communication environments.

• Online disinhibition emerged as a significant predictor of online deviant behaviour.

• The instruments used in the study demonstrated satisfactory internal consistency.

In conclusion, the study highlights the importance of online disinhibition and deindividuation as psychological mechanisms influencing deviant behaviour in digital communication environments. The findings suggest that technological environments that reduce identity cues and social accountability may increase the likelihood of harmful behaviour.

These results emphasize the need to consider psychological factors when designing digital communication systems and developing strategies to promote healthier online interactions.

5.10 Limitations of the Study

• The study adopted a cross-sectional correlational design, which limits the ability to establish causal relationships.

• The use of self-report questionnaires may have introduced response bias or social desirability effects.

• The sample consisted primarily of young adults, limiting the generalizability of the findings to other populations.

• Other potentially influential variables such as personality traits, emotional regulation, and platform-specific factors were not examined.

• The findings should therefore be interpreted within the context of these limitations.

5.11 Recommendations

• Educational institutions should promote awareness regarding responsible online communication and digital citizenship.

• Digital platforms should implement interface features that increase user accountability while maintaining user privacy.

• Online communities may benefit from clear moderation policies and mechanisms that discourage harmful behaviour.

• Platform designers may incorporate behavioural cues and feedback mechanisms that encourage respectful communication.

• Institutions may provide digital literacy programs that educate users about the psychological dynamics of online interaction.

5.12 Suggestions for Future Research

• Future studies may adopt **longitudinal research designs** to examine how online disinhibition and deviant behaviour evolve over time.

• Experimental studies may investigate how specific interface design features influence user behaviour in digital environments.

• Researchers may explore additional psychological variables such as empathy, emotional regulation, personality traits, and moral disengagement.

• Comparative research across different digital platforms may help determine how technological affordances influence behavioural outcomes.

• Qualitative studies may provide deeper insights into how individuals experience anonymity and identity within digital environments.

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APPENDIX

Online Disinhibition Scale (ODS)

Suler, J. (2004). *The Online Disinhibition Effect.* CyberPsychology & Behavior, 7(3), 321–326.
Lapidot-Lefler, N., & Barak, A. (2012). *Effects of anonymity, invisibility, and lack of eye-contact on toxic online disinhibition.* Computers in Human Behavior, 28(2), 434–443.
doi:10.1016/j.chb.2011.10.014

The Online Disinhibition Scale is designed to measure the tendency of individuals to behave more openly or impulsively in online environments compared to face-to-face interactions. The scale captures psychological processes associated with the **Online Disinhibition Effect**, including perceived anonymity, invisibility, reduced authority, and dissociative imagination in digital communication contexts.

The scale used in the present study consists of **23 items** measuring behavioural tendencies associated with online disinhibition across digital platforms such as social media, online forums, and messaging applications.

Participants were asked to indicate how much they agree with each statement based on their typical experiences when interacting online.

Items

1. I feel anonymous when I interact with others online.

2. I feel that others online do not know who I really am.

3. I feel I can hide my real identity online.

4. I feel detached from my real self when I am online.

5. I feel invisible when interacting with others online.

6. I feel that others cannot see me online.

7. I feel less self-conscious when communicating online.

8. I can respond to others online whenever I want.

9. I do not feel pressured to reply immediately online.

10. I can take time to think before responding online.

11. I feel like people online exist mainly in my imagination.

12. I imagine the voices or personalities of people I interact with online.

13. I feel like online interactions are happening in my head.

14. I feel that online interactions are not part of the real world.

15. I feel that my online actions are separate from my offline life.

16. I feel like the online world is not real.

17. I feel less restricted by social rules online.

18. I feel less constrained by authority figures online.

19. I feel less afraid of punishment online.

20. I feel more willing to say things online that I would not say offline.

21. I express myself more freely online.

22. I say things online that I normally would not say face-to-face.

23. I behave more boldly online than in real life.

Scoring Procedure

To obtain the **Online Disinhibition Score (OD)**, add the responses to all items:

OD = 1 + 2 + 3 + … + 23

Higher scores indicate **greater levels of online disinhibition**, reflecting stronger perceptions of anonymity, reduced social constraints, and increased freedom of expression in digital environments.

Online Deviant Behaviour Scale

Hinduja, S., & Patchin, J. W. (2010). *Bullying, cyberbullying, and suicide.* Archives of Suicide Research.

Lowry, P. B., Zhang, J., Wang, C., & Siponen, M. (2016). *Why do adults engage in cyberbullying on social media?* Information Systems Research.
doi:10.17705/1jais.00425

The Online Deviant Behaviour Scale measures the extent to which individuals engage in behaviours that violate accepted social norms within digital environments. These behaviours include harassment, trolling, online hostility, and rule-violating activities across online platforms.

The scale used in the present study consists of **25 items** assessing the frequency of deviant behaviours in online contexts.

Participants indicated how frequently they engaged in each behaviour while using online platforms.

Items

1. Posted offensive or insulting comments about others online.

2. Used obscene or vulgar language in online interactions.

3. Deliberately provoked or flamed others online.

4. Spread rumours or false information about others online.

5. Posted humiliating or embarrassing information about someone online.

6. Insulted or threatened others through social media or messaging apps.

7. Used fake identities to deceive others online.

8. Impersonated someone else online.

9. Cheated in online games or activities.

10. Downloaded pirated software, movies, or music.

11. Visited pornographic or age-inappropriate websites.

12. Shared sexually explicit content online.

13. Engaged in online sexual conversations with strangers.

14. Participated in online gambling activities.

15. Attempted to hack or access others' accounts without permission.

16. Spread viruses or malicious software online.

17. Violated rules of online communities or platforms.

18. Harassed others repeatedly through online communication.

19. Participated in cyberbullying behaviour.

20. Shared private information about others without permission.

21. Used anonymity to behave in ways I would not offline.

22. Engaged in online behaviour that I knew was inappropriate.

23. Encouraged conflicts or arguments online.

24. Posted hateful or discriminatory content online.

25. Repeatedly violated online community guidelines.

Scoring Procedure

To obtain the main scale scores, item responses were summed as follows:

Online Disinhibition (OD) =
1 + 2 + 3 + 4 + 5 + 6 + 7 + 8 + 9 + 10 + 11 + 12 + 13 + 14 + 15 + 16 + 17 + 18 + 19 + 20 + 21 + 22 + 23

Higher scores indicate greater levels of behavioural disinhibition in online communication environments.

Online Deviant Behaviour (ODB) =
1 + 2 + 3 + 4 + 5 + 6 + 7 + 8 + 9 + 10 + 11 + 12 + 13 + 14 + 15 + 16 + 17 + 18 + 19 + 20 + 21 + 22 + 23 + 24 + 25

Higher scores indicate greater engagement in deviant behaviours in digital environments.

Response Format

Participants responded to all items using a 5-point Likert Scale:

A — Strongly Disagree
B — Disagree
C — Neutral
D — Agree
E — Strongly Agree

For behavioural frequency items:

A — Never
B — Rarely
C — Sometimes
D — Often
E — Very Often